

DEMOCRATIC SANCTIONS AND THE SELECTIVE TARGETING OF
AUTHORITARIAN REGIMES
REPLICATION AND EXTENSION PRESENTATION

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WHY ARE SOME DICTATORS SANCTIONED AND OTHERS SPARED?

- ▶ Democratic sanctions are meant to punish authoritarian backsliding.
- ▶ Yet many authoritarian regimes violate democratic norms without being sanctioned.
- ▶ Others are sanctioned quickly after visible political shocks.
- ▶ *Example.* Belarus 2020 vs Bahrain 2011: similar authoritarian backsliding, but only Belarus faced broad Western sanctions.

Core puzzle

If sanctions are not simply a reaction to repression, what other factors are at play?

THE PAPER'S ANSWER

A THREE-PART FRAMEWORK

Trigger

- ▶ Coups
- ▶ Controversial elections

Target vulnerability

- ▶ Weaker regimes
- ▶ Less resilient targets

Sender costs

- ▶ Economic exposure
- ▶ Political alignment

Main Hypothesis

Democratic sanctions depend not only on trigger events, but also on target vulnerability and sender costs.

WHAT EXACTLY I REPLICATED

Design

- ▶ Unit of analysis: authoritarian **country-years**
- ▶ Time window: 1990–2010
- ▶ Outcome: **democratic sanction onset** (binary).
- ▶ Main estimator: **clustered logit** for binary onset

Replicated outputs

- ▶ Table I
- ▶ Table II
- ▶ Table III
- ▶ Figure 2

What is a *clustered logit model*?

Like normal logit, a clustered logit models the probability of a binary outcome. The difference is that it adjusts the standard errors because repeated observations from the same country are likely correlated.

REPLICATION RESULT

DRAMATIC TRIGGERS MATTER MOST

- ▶ The replication recovers the paper's **trigger hierarchy**.
- ▶ **Coups** sharply increase sanction likelihood.
- ▶ **Controversial elections** also matter, but less strongly.
- ▶ Static democratic weakness is less important than visible political shocks.

Interpretation

Sanctions respond most strongly to events that are politically visible and difficult to ignore.

Table I: trigger coefficients

	Western	EU	US
Coup	5.127***	3.765***	4.947***
Democracy score	-0.056	-0.081	-0.116
Controversial election	2.584***	2.620***	2.275***

Table II: predicted probabilities

	Western	EU	US
Baseline	0.007	0.007	0.004
Coup	0.519	0.232	0.346
Controversial election	0.074	0.084	0.032

REPLICATION RESULT

SANCTIONS ARE SELECTIVE, NOT AUTOMATIC

- ▶ Sanctions are not explained by triggers alone.
- ▶ **Target vulnerability** matters: higher **inflation** is associated with higher sanction odds.
- ▶ **Sender costs** matter: politically closer regimes and regimes with higher **FDI** are less likely to be sanctioned.

Interpretation

Even when democratic violations occur, sanctions depend on both **target vulnerability** and **sender costs**.

Table III: selective-targeting coefficients

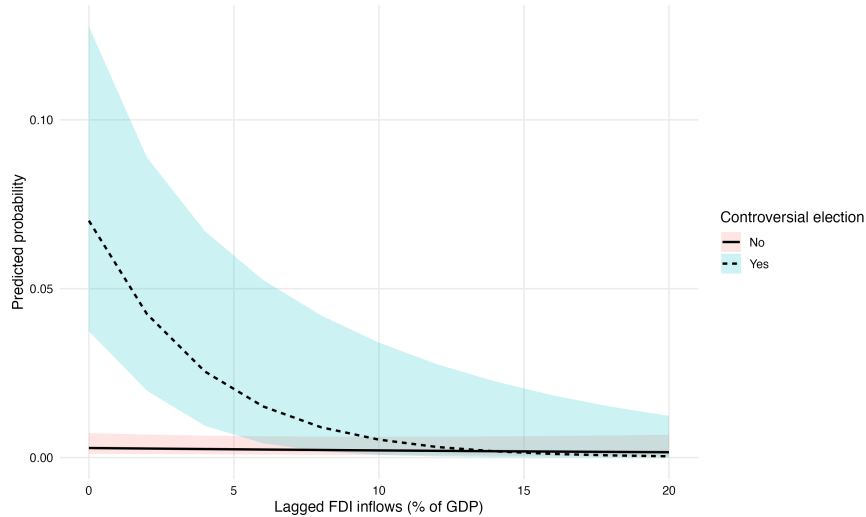
	Western
Coup	5.128***
Controversial election	2.909***
Inflation ($t - 1$)	0.022**
FDI inflows ($t - 1$)	-0.046*
Political closeness to West ($t - 1$)	-4.413**

REPLICATION RESULTS

WHEN SENDER COSTS MATTER MOST

Controversial election × FDI

Table III shows that **sender costs** matter on average. Figure 2 shows *when* one sender-cost variable—**FDI**—matters most: after **controversial elections**.



MY EXTENSION

DOES GEOPOLITICAL ALIGNMENT ALSO SHIELD REGIMES?

Extension question

If economic exposure can shield regimes after weaker triggers, can **political alignment** do the same?

Motivation

- ▶ The paper already shows that political closeness matters overall.
- ▶ Figure 2 suggests discretion is greatest after controversial elections.
- ▶ The natural next step is to test whether political alignment matters *especially there*.

Setup

- ▶ Controversial Election $\times$ High Political Closeness
- ▶ High Closeness = top quartile of UN voting similarity.
- ▶ Coded as a dummy: 1 = top quartile, 0 = lower three quartiles.

EXTENSION RESULT

THE PATTERN IS THERE, BUT CAUTIOUSLY

- ▶ Descriptively, controversial elections are followed by **fewer sanctions** among highly aligned regimes.
- ▶ The interaction term is **negative**, matching the theoretical expectation.
- ▶ The direction is substantively interesting, but the evidence is not strong enough to present as decisive.

Verdict

Theory-consistent and informative, but inferentially uncertain.

Extension model: interaction coefficients

	Baseline	Interaction
Controversial election	2.817***	3.123***
High political closeness (top quartile)	−1.295+	−0.590
Controversial election × high political closeness		−1.784

Observed sanction rates by political closeness

Political closeness	N	Sanctions	Rate
Lower 3 quartiles	59	10	0.169
Top quartile	44	1	0.023

EXTENSION ROBUSTNESS CHECKS

- ▶ I varied the threshold used to define **high political closeness**.
- ▶ The interaction remained **negative** under nearby one-year threshold choices.
- ▶ With a **two-year lag** of political closeness, the interaction weakened and lost directional consistency.
- ▶ Overall, the extension is **plausible but specification-sensitive**.

Takeaway

The robustness checks support a cautious reading: the extension is theory-consistent and informative, but not decisive.

TAKEAWAY

STRONG REPLICATION, MODEST EXTENSION

Replication

- ▶ Core findings are successfully recovered.
- ▶ Coups and controversial elections matter.
- ▶ Sender costs & target vulnerability are central.

Extension

- ▶ Political alignment may also shield regimes.
- ▶ Most plausibly after weaker triggers.
- ▶ Evidence is suggestive, not definitive.

Final message

Democratic sanctions are **selective**: they respond to authoritarian violations, but also to the strategic costs faced by sanctioning states.